

Synadia Content Style Guide

By Mike Blodgett

Writing Goals and Principles

Writing Guidelines

At Synadia, how we talk to the reader differentiates our writing from the pack. We want to create documents that are helpful but don't sound stuffy. Our documentation shouldn't read like boilerplate Enterprise copy. We seek to inform and engage, always willing to lend a helping hand. We are witty yet subtle, funny without trying to be funny. The Synadia way of writing is like the wise, clever Sage in our Hero's journey. With that in mind, here's how to write the Syndadia way.

Be helpful and practical.

We're enthusiastic about helping, but we're also direct. Be concise and get right to the point. Write clear, accurate and brief text that helps the user immediately and then get out of the way. We are writing for everyone, everywhere constantly striving to improve and build trust. The right content, at the right time.

Be caring.

We listen to our customers and try to understand where they're coming from in their journey. We know how difficult it can be to implement new tech because we've all been there at some point.

Be honest.

Trust is something that takes ages to build and moments to squander. We are truthful in our writing and we never miss an opportunity to build upon that to strengthen our relationship to our customers.

Be optimistic and fun.

Our language is conversational and instructive. Our tech is genuinely exciting, and so our writing reflects that emotion.

Be opinionated.

Be explicitly opinionated. We are the experts, we know what works because we've seen what doesn't. Your perspective is the one our customers need, tried and true.

Inclusive Language

What is inclusive language? The Guidelines for Inclusive Language, published by the Linguistic Society of America (LSA), define inclusive language as language that “acknowledges diversity, conveys respect to all people, is sensitive to differences, and promotes equal opportunities.

In short, Inclusive language is free from words, phrases, or tones that reflect prejudiced, stereotyped or discriminatory views of particular people. We keep the individual as the most important part of the sentiment and don't concentrate on characteristics like gender, sexual orientation, religion, racial group, or ability unless it's relevant to the discussion.

Some of this is new or can be confusing, so **if you aren't sure, ask**. Strive to include language that reflects peoples' choice and style in how they talk about themselves.

Best practices

- Don't use terms or phrases that have religious origins.
- Don't use expressions that ignore the history and achievements of any culture.
- Avoid using language where the cultural beliefs, values, and traditions are centered on the dominant culture or that perpetuates a 'them and us' mentality.
- Avoid emphasis on differences between any groups of people
- Avoid stereotyping or positive/negative generalizations
- Avoid promotion of ethnic or racial invisibility
- Only mention disabilities when it's relevant. If you've designed a feature specifically for people who are blind, great, but avoid just throwing it into your text when it's not relevant.
- Focus on the person rather than a disability.
- Avoid suggesting victimhood.

Voice and Tone

We use the Synadia voice across all of our properties and products. Our voice is based on the Synadia brand personality traits of helpful, caring, honest, and optimistic and is always the same - providing a consistent, friendly, helpful guide to our users.

Consistency of voice speaks to the authenticity of our products. We want to build relationships, and how we communicate is a key part of that.

There are times when you need to speak to different subsets of users, for instance among different personas, and your tone might not be quite the same. That's okay!

We've provided enough guidance to help adjust our tone to accommodate for:

- Where people are at in their journey
- Their emotional state
- The product or property you are writing for

But what is the difference between voice and tone?

Voice is our personality, tone is our mood

When writing in Synadia's voice, we're the guide, the leader. We're the sage-like character to our customer's hero; more of a Merlin/Gandalf type. Our wisdom may be mysterious, but our guidance is to the point. We know when it's time to be serious and direct, and when it's time to be a little loose.

Who these principles are for

Any Synadian who works with customer-facing communications should follow the voice and tone principles: product managers, content designers, developers, designers, marketers, advocates, support engineers, blog contributors... pretty much everyone.

We stick to our voice and tone across all our channels and properties, from blogs, microsites, video, emails, tweets, and other external communications to in-product user interfaces, labels, error messages, menus, and more.

When to use the principles

We speak our minds by offering solutions that will be useful to people in the now. To help them do the best work of their lives, we try to inspire and push teams to try new things by simplifying complex problems into easy to understand pieces.

With a familiar tone, clear language, and a solid knowledge of our audience, we craft messages that get teams moving in the right direction, then we get out of their way, so they can get to work.

Voice and tone principles

Inform to build trust

Why: To inform and share what the audience needs to know at that moment and nothing more. Be cognizant of when a user is new or confused, and tone down the boldness by being more prescriptive. Let people know where they are in their journey and what they are looking at in the product.

How: Write as if you are a wizened member of the team. Show up at the right time and be open, humble, and warm - offer direction for the most appropriate next steps and get out of the way.

When: Use when we're trying to be informative and to build trust.

Empower to inspire action

Why: To educate where we think people need it most. Offer best practices and recommendations for next steps while suggesting ways to improve and make decisions.

How: Write as if you are educating. You are a teacher with empathy and understanding of what it's like to be in the weeds. You expect your audience to have a basic understanding.

When:

- When something requires an action from the user
- When there is an educational opportunity
- When there is a social opportunity

Encourage people along their journey

Why: To inspire initial optimism by providing support in the right place. Be consistent and dependable.

How: Write in an upbeat, friendly way. Acknowledge the opportunities in the here-and-now and walk through it with them.

When:

- New to Synadia, evaluators, or when introducing a new concept, feature, or product
- When something requires an action from the user

Motivate by showing the “what could go right”

Why: Provide incentive and excitement for continued growth. Consider why someone would want to do this.

How: Focus more on the solution than on the problem. Show people the possible benefits.

When: There is an educational opportunity it's a chance to tell them how other industry leaders do it, give best practices, and tips & tricks.

Earn trust by meeting customers where they are right now

Why: Give people what they need. Provide quick and thorough answers, guidance, actions, and instructions.

How: Write as if you are explaining to your friend how to hook up a flat-screen tv.

When: Whenever possible, try to be practical.

Delight through exciting experiences

Why: Once we've built trust, we try to delight without overdoing it. The experience and expectation should be level-set, repetitive, and conscientious. We're giving balloons, not hot air balloon rides.

How: Write to convey excitement. You are giving a pat on the back for a job well done.

When:

- In product, we use it in success messages, and modal dialogs
- During social interactions and while introducing new experiences

Writing About People

Personas

Sponsors

Gain business value from NATS. Owners of the use case definition and responsible for the business goals established for NATS.

Developers

Build progressive distributed application with location transparent messaging, streaming, key-value, and object storage APIs using a single client SDK, supported in all major languages.

Architects

Design and dynamically adapt topologies spanning multiple clouds, geographies, and extending to the edge without interrupting existing workloads.

Operators

Use built-in server management, security, and monitoring tooling enabling complete visibility and control over the entire system.

Grammar and Mechanics

Abbreviations

Don't use internal abbreviations in customer-facing copy.

Don't use apostrophes for plural abbreviations.

Don't use i.e. or e.g. They are not localization friendly.

Yes: Jira Service Desk, jira.Synadia.com, developer.Synadia.com

No: JSD, JAC, DAC, CD's, 1980's, i.e., e.g.

Active voice

One of the two "voices" of verbs. When the verb of a sentence is in the active voice, the subject is doing the acting, as in the sentence "Kevin hit the ball." Kevin (the subject of the sentence) acts in relation to the ball.

Yes: Administrators control user access to Synadia Cloud applications.

No: User access to Synadia Cloud applications is controlled by administrators.

Bold

Use bold text to draw the reader's eye to key phrases and statements in your email and web content.

For product copy or help articles, use bold for static UI elements like menu items, buttons, screen headings, and anything else you want to call attention to.

If you need to bold an element but the UI doesn't support it, for example, in a dialog header or a UI message, you can use italics instead.

Use italics for fields that might change, like a page name. See italics for more guidelines.

Yes: Go to General Configuration > User Macros.

No: Go to the settings page and select Configuration.

Capitalization

Use sentence case in all titles, headings, menu items, labels, and buttons.

Yes: This is the new Jira experience!

No: This Is The New JIRA Experience!

Double no: tHiS iS tHe nEw JIRA eXpErleNcE!

Colons

Use colons to introduce a bulleted list or series of steps. Don't use colons at the end of headings.

Contractions

In keeping with our more conversational, friendly voice, use contractions.

Use curly apostrophes wherever possible in UI copy by typing option+shift+] on a Mac.

Yes: Can't, don't, it's

No: Cannot, can not, it is, it's (not curly)

Dashes

Use em dashes sparingly to indicate an abrupt or dramatic change in a sentence — like this. If the break happens in the middle of a sentence — like this — use em dashes on either side of the phrase.

Em dashes can help avoid confusion when the phrase being set apart contains several commas, such as a mid-sentence list. In general, though, try to keep sentences as short and simple as possible to avoid excessively complex punctuation.

Use spaces on either side of an em dash. Use option-shift-hyphen to make an em dash on a Mac.

For ranges of numbers, use a hyphen with no spaces — not an em or en dash.

Yes: The newly released Jira 6 — our best Jira yet — will be available next week.

No: The newly released Jira 6—our best Jira yet—will be available next week.

Yes: He said his friends — Mike, Charlie, and Scott — would be arriving late. They should arrive anywhere from 2-4.

No: He said his friends - Mike, Charlie, and Scott - would be arriving late. They should arrive anywhere from 2—4.

Dates and times

See Date and time guidelines.

Direct quotes

Quote with curly quotes, not italics. See [Quotation marks](#) for details.

Yes: “Synadia Software is the best software ever!” said Charlie.

No: Synadia Software is just ok. said Charlie.

Ellipses (...)

Quotes

Don’t put spaces in-between the periods in an ellipsis. When using an ellipsis to omit part of a long quote, include spaces on either side of the ellipsis (...).

Yes: “From medicine and space travel, to disaster response ... our products help teams all over the planet advance humanity through the power of software.” Synadia: Discover our story.

Truncation

Ellipses sometimes show that text was cut off or truncated when a message doesn’t fit in the given space. Avoid truncation whenever possible using these techniques:

Shorten UI messages and front-load important information.

Wrap the text or use other techniques instead of truncating.

Test your designs using multiple screen widths and magnification levels to ensure it doesn’t truncate.

When you can't avoid truncation, provide an alternative way to view the full text for accessibility and usability.

In Synadia Design System components that truncate, the ellipsis appears without any space next to the last visible character (for example, Sign up for...).

Yes: This message is trunca...

Exclamation marks

Avoid exclamation marks! They should only be used for exciting or new things! At most, there should only be one exclamation mark per page!

Gender

When possible, avoid gendered pronouns. If you can't, then they or their is preferable to his or her or he or she.

Yes: Ask your admin to add you.

Yes: Ask your admin if they can add you.

No: Ask your admin if he or she can add you.

Hyphens

Use hyphens to form a single idea from multiple words. In general, only use hyphens when they help to avoid confusion or ambiguity.

When two or more words function together as a descriptor or adjective (also known as a compound modifier), we typically hyphenate those words if they precede the noun they describe, but don't hyphenate if they come after the noun. There are exceptions to this rule, such as with the word very or any adverbs ending in -ly.

Yes: Fast-moving trucks, ice-cold drinks, dog-friendly hotels. The hotel is dog friendly.

No: Very-interesting topics, poorly-worded sentences.

Most prefixes don't require hyphens to be understood. Only use a hyphen if not doing so causes confusion or ambiguity. Consult a modern dictionary to be sure.

Yes: Autocorrect, coworker, and preexisting are all fine without a hyphen. Recreating in a park, however, is different from re-creating a page. I could resign from my job one day, then re-sign my contract the next.

No: Avoid creating nonsense words when using prefixes without hyphens, such as nonlife in nonlife-threatening.

Use hyphens for number ranges with no spaces on either side. For example, see rows 1-4 in the table.

There are always exceptions, and some commonly hyphenated words can become closed over time (remember e-mail?). Check Vocabulary for more specific hyphenated word guidance.

Italics

Use italics for emphasis, citations, or defining a term. You can also use it for UI elements that might change, like a field name or user input.

You can also use italics in places where you would normally use bold but the UI doesn't support it. For example, in a dialog header or UI message.

Don't use italics if the item is also a hyperlink.

See **bold** for more information about how to format UI elements.

Yes: A JIRA workflow is the set of statuses and transitions that an issue goes through during its lifecycle.

Yes: According to the 2008 IT Unplugged report, IT is really unplugged!

Yes: For example, if you create a metric called Time to resolution, other projects can create metrics with that name.

No: To learn more, see the 2008 IT Unplugged report

No: In your project, select Settings>Request types

Lists

Use lists to draw the reader's eye and make items easier to scan and follow. Use proper punctuation in your items if they are complete sentences. Try to limit lists to six items or less. If you need more items, see if you can split the list into multiple lists.

Bulleted

Use bulleted lists for options, or a list where the order of the items doesn't matter. Phrase each item in a parallel way. If the bullets complete the introductory sentence, start the fragments with lowercase and skip the periods.

Yes:

Due to security concerns, all employees are now required to:

- wear an identification tag in the building
- identify themselves when answering the phone
- use their identification tag to enter or leave before 7 AM and after 6 PM
- alert security if a suspicious package is found

No:

Due to security concerns, all employees are now required to follow the regulations below:

- Wear an identification tag when in the company building
- Employees who answer the phone must first identify themselves
- Entering the building before 7 AM and after 6 PM requires that employees use their identification tag to enter or leave the building
- When opening all packages, alert security if the package is suspicious.

Numbered

Use numbered lists for tasks, or lists where the order of the items matters. Unlike with bulleted lists, always capitalize the first word in each item and end the item with a period.

You don't need to create a list for tasks that have two or fewer steps.

To add a new user macro:

1. Go to Settings > General Configuration > User Macros.
2. Choose Create a User Macro.
3. Enter the macro details.

Monospaced text

Use monospaced font for names of a file or directory. It is mostly used in administrator and developer docs.

For example: The location of the Home directory is stored in a configuration file called **confluence-init.properties** which is located in the **confluence/WEB-INF/classes** directory in your Confluence Installation directory.

Numbers

Write out numbers one through ten. After ten, you can use 11, 12, 108, and so on.

One word or two?

Can't remember if it's filesystem or file system? Check out our Word List and Definitions.

Oxford comma

Use the Oxford or serial comma to offset the final item in a list. When in doubt, add the comma before your “and” or “or”.

Yes: We use sentence case in all titles, headings, menu items, and buttons.

No: We use sentence case in all titles, headings, menu items and buttons.

Periods (full stops)

Use only one space after a period. Avoid periods in headers, titles, tooltips, field descriptions, and menu names. Use them to complete description text in the product, messages, and notifications. Don't use them in a bulleted list unless the list item is a complete sentence.

Yes: Public room

No: Public room.

Possessives

Use 's to show possession, even if the word ends in s. Use curly apostrophes by typing option+shift+] on Mac.

Yes: James's book

Yes: a week's time

No: James' book

Pronouns

In most cases, second person is best. It fits Synadia's casual, conversational tone to refer to the reader directly with you. Exceptions can be made for specific types of writing, such as whitepapers and press releases.

Not sure whether it's My projects or Your projects? For best results, avoid using mine, my, or your in UI copy.

If you need to use mine, my, or your, the rule of thumb is to think of the UI as a conversation between the system and the user.

If the system is presenting information to the user, such as in a dialog box, then your is more appropriate, because it's like saying "Here are your things", or "What would you like to do?"

If the user is performing an action, such as clicking a button or a link, then mine/my is more appropriate, because it's like saying "Show me my stuff!"

Yes: Bitbucket will change your life.

Yes: Your team will love using pull requests in Bitbucket.

No: Teams love using pull requests in Bitbucket.

Quotation marks

Use double quotes ("") for direct quotes. For UI elements, page titles, and other objects, use bold or italicized text as appropriate.

Use curly quotes in any UI or body copy, unless you're writing in code or there is a semantic reason to use straight quotes. To create curly quotation marks, use option+[for opening and option+shift+[for closing quotation marks on a Mac.

Punctuation goes inside the quotation marks.

Yes: "We have big things planned for the coming year," said Mike and Scott.

Yes: He called quokkas "the cutest animal ever."

No: Add a comment to the "Team process" page.

No: The shark said "Surfers are delicious".

Style

Five great guidelines for clear, concise writing, courtesy of George Orwell:

- Don't use a metaphor, simile, or other figures of speech that you commonly see.
- Don't use a long word if a shorter one will do.
- If you can omit a word, do it.
- Use active voice.
- Don't use foreign phrases, scientific nomenclature, or jargon if there's an everyday word you can use instead.

Titles and headings

Use sentence case. Don't use bold, italics, or standard punctuation in headings. It's ok to use question marks and exclamation points if they fit the criteria for those two marvelous pieces of punctuation.

- Capitalize the first word of a title or heading (sentence case)
- Capitalize proper nouns and any trademarked names (products, countries, people's names, etc...)
- Don't use full stops

Articles

The use of articles (the, a, an) in headings depends on whether the message is conversational or action-based microcopy. Avoid articles in buttons and labels.

Documentation

Phrase documentation heading (H1s) with an action verb. Using action verbs informs the user of the type of content they can expect to find (for example, Learn versus Get). Don't use gerunds.

A gerund is a verb in its present participle form (root verb + "ing") that acts as a noun in a sentence..

Yes: Create a page

No: Creating a page

More documentation guidelines for Synadia employees (login required).

UI elements

Use sentence case, even if the UI element does not

Use bold to call out the UI element in a step. Don't bold the >.

If the UI element has an icon, use both the name and the icon.

Go to More ••• > Link issues.

US English

We write with US English spelling and punctuation.

When all else fails

Follow the AP Style Guide.

Do not assume auto-correct is correct. Auto-correct is suggestive, not prescriptive.

Please be aware that suggested changes may conflict with this guide, in which case, this guide wins.

